

Artificial Intelligence

infra/STRUCTURE Summit 2026: Brownfield, Capital Depth, and the Maturing Neocloud Stack

CITI'S TAKE

The infra/STRUCTURE Summit in Las Vegas this week signaled that the data center build-out is entering a more disciplined, capital-intensive, and operationally sophisticated phase as public sentiment becomes an ever more important factor for delivery timelines. Developers are increasingly looking to brownfield and retrofit sites, leveraging existing power connections, legacy facilities, and pre-entitled land, to compress permitting timelines that can otherwise add years beyond compute demand. Concurrently, capital pools financing the build-out are deepening and widening, with insurance companies, pension funds, and banks adding to GPU and power infrastructure underwriting alongside traditional real estate and infrastructure funds, reflecting the scale of financing required over the next five-to-ten years, even as early signs of a GPU supply inflection (B300s increasingly visible on secondary channels, per Hosted.ai) suggest the historically chip supply-constrained backdrop may be easing faster than consensus assumes.

On the operating side, the neocloud industry is maturing past its "bare metal" phase. Platforms such as Hosted.ai and Hydra Host are virtualizing GPU fleets to match fragmented supply with fragmented demand, lifting utilization from the 20-40% range typical of dedicated infrastructure to 60-90%, according to Hosted.ai, and compressing time-to-billable-revenue from months to hours. This mirrors the broader shift toward cloud-style economics across the ecosystem with multi-tenancy, token-based monetization, and specialized serving architectures, where pairing GPUs for prefill with dedicated decode accelerators (e.g., SambaNova's RDUs) is compressing payback periods and addressing the utilization drag (73-90% degradation cited on Blackwell per SambaNova) caused by rapidly rising context windows. We see this virtualization, architectural specialization, and ecosystem buildout as a structural tailwind for returns on existing and incremental GPU capacity, and a potential near-term efficiency/ROI unlock for neoclouds and other inference service providers.

The key overhang remains community and political sentiment, which multiple panelists flagged as actively hampering project development and delivery timelines, with over 400 U.S. communities imposing restrictions or moratoriums since January. The consistent message across site selectors, financiers, and operators was that this dynamic will likely get worse before it gets better. Panelists believe public opposition is increasingly a referendum on AI broadly rather than data centers specifically, and is expected to persist independent of the midterm election cycle. Industry responses (the "Infrastructure for America" pledge, elimination of NDAs and evaporative cooling, concrete community investment) are nascent but underscore

Heath Terry^{AC}

+1-212-723-4624

heath.terry@citi.com

Shelby Spencer

+1-212-816-0416

shelby.spencer@citi.com

Ashley Kim

+1-212-816-6689

ashley.kim@citi.com

Janna Withrow

+1-212-723-0439

janna.withrow@citi.com

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that execution risk has shifted from pure supply-chain and power constraints toward social license to operate. In terms of development costs, groups beginning to convert brownfield sites into speculative inference 10-50MW sites are seeing the premium for land continuing to widen over time from quotes of \$300K-500K/MW before to \$2M-3M/MW today.

Energy infrastructure platform Oklo's framing was that construction timelines for nuclear power plants are faster than getting a usable grid interconnection, positioning pre-secured, grid-queued land as the scarce, investable asset. One digital infrastructure advisory firm cited over 16GW of powered land projects already facilitated and strong pipeline demand from both DC and compute operators willing to pay for speed-to-power. In terms of advanced nuclear's contribution to AI power demand, Oklo talked about nuclear fuel, not reactor technology or permitting, as the binding constraint. With Russia supplying 44% of global enriched fuel (banned from U.S. import) and domestic enrichment at just 7%, Oklo and peers are focused on acquiring scarce fresh-fuel contracts, high-enriched government stockpiles, and recycling capacity years ahead of need. Absent secured fuel pathways, utilities and developers looking to advanced nuclear to meet mid-decade power commitments could find themselves "boxed up" by the mid-to-late 2030s, making fuel supply chain exposure (enrichment, recycling, government stockpile access) a differentiator worth tracking alongside site and power-purchase-agreement announcements.

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